when the imperial troops reached Sarangpur in present-day Madhya Pradesh, Adham Khan was caught completely unawares and he quailed when he understood the meaning behind this sudden, explosive arrival. When the harem along with Maham Anaga arrived the next day, she quickly brought her son back to his senses and arranged for a lavish banquet at which Adham Khan hurried to present to the Padshah ‘everything he had taken from Baz Bahadur’s estate, animate and inanimate’, and immense treasure thus poured into the imperial coffers. Unfortunately, this was not the end of Adham Khan’s presumptuous behaviour. He convinced some of his mother’s servants to bring away two ‘rare beauties’ of Baz Bahadur’s from within the imperial harem itself. These dancing girls were particularly valued because the courts of Malwa had long patronized music and dance, first under Sultan Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq, and then under Baz Bahadur, and the exquisite precision and grace of their technique were known and admired. When Maham Anaga realized what her son had done, she knew that this was an insolence Akbar would no longer tolerate. She had the two young women killed so that Akbar would never find out about Adham Khan’s insane act of transgression. Akbar did not say anything further about the matter to Adham Khan but the Padshah was only biding his time. The world had changed while Adham Khan was in Malwa and no longer would the Padshah forgive those who acted against his imperial dignity, even if they were the favoured ones.

This violent episode of the murder of the dancers from Malwa also highlights a troubling and easily erased aspect of ancient and medieval history—the enslavement of women. Female slaves were an integral part of affluent households while even simpler homes like those of merchants and cultivators owned a few such slaves who were often acquired during raids on enemy clans and kingdoms. These women then spent their lives carrying out the endless domestic duties which were indispensable in a household such as cutting vegetables, grinding flour, sweeping, smearing the floor with cow dung, bringing in the firewood, transporting water, dealing with human waste, weeding, cutting grass and so on in a brutal cycle of exhaustion. Many were forced into concubinage with the men of the house. These women could be from varied backgrounds and Ibn Battuta, the fourteenth-century traveller from Morocco, writes of captives being cheap as ‘they are dirty and do not know the civilized ways’. These plain women were more likely to be used for menial jobs while more accomplished